international opinion.[84] Thus it should come as no surprise that the views of many Burmese Buddhists are echoed in the narrative of the 969 Movement.

There are plenty of pro-Buddhist websites, reports, articles and books that present far less subtle versions of such arguments. Some of this material is quite explicit in its goal of addressing what it sees as a mortal threat to Buddhist Myanmar and argues that the idea of the 'Rohingyas' is a recent invention. For example, take the book by Zan and Chan called *Influx Viruses*,[85] which claims:

> There is a new trend concerning the so-called Rohingya. This trend, fashioned by some Islamic radicals after Burma's independence, his been problematic, and a grave concern for (a) the Arakanese, (b) the people of Burma and (c) historians and scholars. A proper understanding of the importance and nature of illegal Muslim immigrant flow is crucial to comprehensively address the imperative issue of development contest. Rohingya movements have been accompanied by certain dangers and challenges, particularly for the Arakan State…[86] [grammatical errors and spelling mistakes in the original text have been retained]

The rest of *Influx Viruses* is a long diatribe about the alleged falsehoods put forward by those unfriendly to modern-day Myanmar. It argues for the essentially Buddhist and Burmese characteristics of the kingdoms in Rakhine before 1785, but goes further than Leider in claiming that the Muslim presence in the region before 1824 was minimal.

But the 1871 census notes that the 64,000 'Mussulmen' in Rakhine differ 'from the Arakanese but little, except in their religion and social customs which their religion directs'.[87] If we set aside the lordly indifference of the colonial power to the real differences between those they ruled, this is indicative that for all practical purposes the Rohingyas and the Rakhine were very similar populations which had lived together for a very long time indeed.

Summary

The historical pattern of the expansion and contraction of a core state based around particular ethnic and religious communities is not unusual. Equally, many modern post-colonial states were effectively delineated for the administrative convenience of the imperial power, and Burma was no exception. The consequence is a post-colonial world where many states have complex mixes of ethnic groups, and there are many regions with ethnic groups splintered across multiple states. However, what this does not